

Which of the following scenarios best represents intragenerational vertical mobility?

- ☐ A. An hourly wage employee has a son who becomes a neurosurgeon. [30%]
- ✓ ☒ B. A cardiologist loses her medical license and struggles to find a new job. [52%]
- ☐ C. A general surgeon in Denver moves his surgical practice to Dallas. [4%]
- ☐ D. A dentist inherits his mother's dental practice. [12%]

Correct

52% answered correctly

Explanation:

Types of social mobility			
Direction of movement			
	No change in social status ↔	Increase in social status ↑	Decrease in social status ↓
1 Generation	Intragenerational horizontal mobility (eg, doctor moves her practice from Atlanta to Chicago)	Intragenerational upward mobility (eg, after 10 years, nurse goes back to school to earn MD)	Intragenerational downward mobility (eg, doctor loses license to practice medicine)
2+ Generations	Intergenerational horizontal mobility (eg, son of doctors becomes a doctor)	Intergenerational upward mobility (eg, son of high school drop-outs becomes a doctor)	Intergenerational downward mobility (eg, son of doctors becomes a high school drop-out)

Social mobility refers to the change or **movement of individuals**, groups, or families between or within **status** categories in society (eg, from middle class to upper class). Social mobility can be **horizontal** (ie, same social status) or **vertical** (ie, up or down in social status) and is related to a multitude of other factors, such as educational achievement, job loss, career advancement, marriage, and institutionalized discrimination.

Intragenerational social mobility occurs within a **single generation** (ie, within a lifetime).

Intergenerational social mobility occurs over **multiple generations** (ie, across several lifetimes).

A cardiologist who loses her medical license and struggles to find a new job is an example of both *intragenerational* mobility, as this shift occurs within her own lifetime, and vertical (downward) mobility, because her social status decreases.

(Choice A) A difference in social status between parent and son reflects *intergenerational* mobility, as it occurs across more than one lifetime. The shift in status from parent (hourly wage employee) to son (neurosurgeon, a highly paid salaried position) is an example of vertical (upward) social mobility.

(Choice C) A surgeon moving his practice between locations does represent *intragenerational* mobility, as it occurs within his own lifetime, but it would be an example of horizontal (not vertical) social mobility because there is no change in social status.

(Choice D) A dentist inheriting his mother's dental practice would be an example of *intergenerational* (not *intragenerational*) mobility, as it occurs across more than one lifetime. It is also an example of horizontal (not vertical) social mobility because the status of mother and son are the same.

Educational objective:

Social mobility refers to the change in social status experienced by a group or individual. It may be vertical (upward or downward) or horizontal (no change in status) and may be intragenerational (occurring over a relatively short time among members of the same generation) or intergenerational (occurring over a relatively long time among members of different generations).